with the Chinese – even as the threat of invasion hung over the entire process.

Having spurned American overtures to supply military aid, Nehru and India's foreign policy establishment concluded that India had no effective method to check a potential Chinese advance, beyond diplomatic outreach. Rather than assert their own counterclaims, Indian diplomacy set out to demonstrate its friendly disposition by obstructing American efforts to arm Tibet, discouraging any attempt to raise the issue at the United Nations, acquiescing to Chinese claims of sovereignty and their takeover of Tibet, encouraging the Tibetan mission to accept defeat and continuing to espouse China's cause before the world. Instead of opposing China's claims because they threatened its security and its legal rights, India continually pointed out the difficulties that a Chinese invasion of Tibet would create for its worldwide advocacy of the Chinese cause. The political scientist Dawa Norbu summed up the situation: '[T]he essential functions of Nehruvian India in the communist scheme of things were not only to prevent external intervention in Tibet but also to seek India's legitimation of the communist takeover.'[57]

In the attempt to distance India from the US and demonstrate friendship with China – negating Chinese propaganda of Nehru being a Western stooge – Tibet was an early casualty. The fate of the ongoing negotiations were sealed when the People's Liberation Army marched into Tibet in October 1950. Even after the invasion, Nehru continued to reject American offers of help to 'avoid giving credence to Peking's charges that great powers had been intriguing in Tibet and had been exercising influence over India's Tibet policies'.[58] By then, so far had Indian diplomacy drifted that when Nehru instructed Ambassador Panikkar to make a forceful argument to the Chinese to stop their invasion – though only because they were making it difficult for him to continue to champion their cause – Panikkar refused and promptly sent a reply justifying Mao's actions and blaming the Tibetans for bringing the invasion on themselves.[59]